

Kant-Extra:

Introduction

Normative ethics seeks principles that tell us what we ought to do. Immanuel Kant's deontological theory, with its emphasis on duty and autonomy, is one of the central normative theories. Kant argues that the **Categorical Imperative (CI)**—a principle of practical reason—provides an objective, unconditional standard that applies to all rational agents, regardless of their desires or ends[1]. Moral requirements derive from this principle, so all immoral actions are irrational because they violate the CI. This literature review summarises Kantianism's core features, arguments in its favour, major criticisms and thought-experiments illustrating its successes and failures.

Core principles of Kantianism

Good Will and Duty

Kant argues that the only thing good without qualification is **a good will**, a will that acts for duty's sake rather than from self-interest or inclination. Actions done from inclination lack moral value; only those motivated by duty have moral worth[2]. Duties are commands of practical reason. Kant distinguishes **perfect duties**—precise, exceptionless prohibitions such as not stealing or not lying—from **imperfect duties** like beneficence or developing one's talents. Imperfect duties allow latitude in how they are fulfilled[3].

Hypothetical versus Categorical Imperatives

A **hypothetical imperative** tells you to do X if you want Y (e.g., “study if you want to pass”). Because such imperatives depend on contingent desires, they cannot serve as the basis of moral law. Instead, moral requirements must be **categorical imperatives**—unconditional commands that hold regardless of one's ends. Kant emphasises that the CI is purely formal: it expresses the form of a universally binding law rather than contingent ends[4].

Three formulations of the Categorical Imperative

1. **Universal Law formulation:** act only on that maxim that you can will to become a universal law[5]. The test requires determining whether the maxim of one's action could be universally adopted without contradiction.
2. **Humanity formulation:** treat humanity, whether in oneself or others, always as an end and never merely as a means[6]. Rational beings have intrinsic value; using someone purely as a tool is immoral.
3. **Kingdom of Ends formulation:** act as if through your maxims you were legislating laws for a society of rational beings who respect each other's autonomy[7].

These formulations are intended to be equivalent; they emphasise universality, intrinsic value and rational self-legislation.

Autonomy and moral status

Kant grounds morality in **autonomy**: a rational will is self-legislating, giving the moral law to itself[8]. Autonomy presupposes free will. Because rational agents legislate the moral law, they have **dignity** and must be respected as ends in themselves[6]. Critics note that Kant's focus on rational capacities may exclude humans with severe cognitive disabilities from basic moral status, since they lack the moral capacities and dispositions Kant regards as essential[9].

Arguments in favour of Kantianism

Universality and fairness

The universal law formulation ensures that moral rules are impartial and consistent. One cannot make oneself an exception: a maxim such as "I will lie when it benefits me" cannot be universalised, because universal lying would destroy the institution of truth-telling[10]. The CI thus prevents self-serving exceptions and promotes fairness: you cannot will a rule that benefits you while expecting others to act differently[11].

Respect for persons and human dignity

The humanity formulation demands that we always treat others as ends rather than mere means. This underlies Kant's condemnation of deception, coercion and exploitation. For example, lying to conceal adultery manipulates the other person as a mere means[12]. The same principle informs Kant's view of **retributive justice**: punishment should never use a person merely as a tool for social benefit but must treat the offender as an end and punish only the guilty[13]. Punishing the innocent to deter crime is categorically rejected, no matter how useful it might be[14].

Autonomy and moral agency

Kantian ethics emphasises that moral laws arise from rational autonomy. Because rational agents legislate the moral law for themselves, obeying the law is an expression of one's own will[8]. This view portrays humans as active participants in morality rather than passive receivers of commands.

Clarity of moral duties

Kant's distinction between perfect and imperfect duties gives structure to moral obligations. Perfect duties, such as keeping promises or not stealing, admit no exceptions; imperfect duties, such as charity or self-improvement, allow discretion[3]. This framework explains why some moral rules are absolute while others are more flexible.

Application to thought experiments

Trolley problems. Kantianism helps explain differing intuitions in trolley cases. In the standard scenario, flipping a switch diverts a runaway trolley, saving five at the cost of one. A second variant involves pushing a large man off a footbridge to stop the trolley. The Kantian argues that flipping the switch is permissible because the death of the one is an unintended side effect, whereas pushing the man uses him as a mere means; his death is the means by which the trolley is stopped[15]. This use of the humanity formulation aligns with many people's intuitions.

Retributive justice. Kant opposes utilitarian theories of punishment. Punishment can never be inflicted as a means to promote social good; it is justified only when someone deserves it[13]. Punishments must be proportional to the offender's "inner wickedness" and must respect their

humanity[16]. Kant's retributivism forbids punishing the innocent to deter crime and rejects overly severe punishments even if they would save lives[14][17]. These ideas resonate with common intuitions about justice and equality.

Criticisms of Kantianism

Empty formalism and contentlessness

Hegel and other critics argue that the CI is **empty formalism**: it tests only the logical consistency of maxims rather than their moral content. By adding arbitrary conditions to maxims, one can often universalise immoral actions. For example, the maxim "steal from people with nine-letter names" can be universalised without undermining private property[18]. Conversely, the harmless maxim "be in the top 10% of students" cannot be universalised since only 10% of people can succeed[19]. Such examples suggest that universalizability alone cannot determine moral rightness.

Ignoring consequences

Kant's ethics focuses on duty and denies that moral rightness depends on outcomes. Critics argue that this leads to implausible verdicts. In the trolley problem, Kant forbids killing one person even to save five[20]. He also holds that stealing to feed one's starving family or lying to save someone's life is wrong because these acts violate perfect duties[21]. Many moral intuitions regard consequences as morally relevant, especially when fundamental interests like life or survival are at stake.

Rigorism and conflicts of duties

Kant insists that perfect duties allow no exceptions and denies the possibility of genuine conflicts between duties[22]. Thought experiments such as lying to a murderer at the door or promises that cannot be kept without committing another wrong challenge this claim. When one makes a promise that can be fulfilled only by lying or stealing, whichever choice one makes seems to violate a duty[23]. Kant argues that such apparent conflicts result from incorrectly formulated maxims, but critics see them as genuine moral dilemmas.

Limited moral motivation

Because only actions done from duty have moral worth, Kantianism appears to devalue actions motivated by love or compassion. Visiting a friend in hospital out of genuine concern has “no moral value,” whereas doing it reluctantly out of duty does[24]. Many argue that moral worth should include virtuous motives such as benevolence and friendship.

Problem of cognitive disability and personhood

The SEP notes that Kant bases moral status on rational capacities. Some humans with severe cognitive disabilities appear to lack the capacities needed to legislate and follow moral laws[9]. Critics contend that this implication is ethically unacceptable and that moral worth should not depend solely on rationality.

Meta-ethical challenges and free will

Michael Huemer criticises Kant’s attempt to reconcile free will with determinism. He argues that distinguishing between a “sensible” and an “intelligible” world fails to resolve the conflict and that the notion of actions caused solely by internal factors is dubious[25]. Huemer further argues that the first formulation of the CI does not uniquely determine moral duties: because it lacks substantive content, virtually any moral system could pass its universalization test[26]. He claims that Kant’s derivations of duties such as not committing suicide or keeping promises rely on empirical assumptions rather than logical contradictions[27].

Hypothetical versus categorical imperatives

Philosopher Philippa Foot contends that moral rules are not genuine categorical imperatives. Someone who rejects morality cannot be accused of inconsistency or irrationality. Foot argues that moral requirements are **hypothetical imperatives**: reasons to act arise only if one has particular desires or aims[28]. Thus, Kant’s claim that morality has unconditional rational authority is challenged.

Thought experiments: success and failure

Success: Trolley dilemma and respect for persons

The Kantian distinction between intending harm and merely foreseeing harm explains our intuitions in trolley problems. Diverting a trolley onto a track where one person will die is permissible because the person's death is a foreseen but not intended means to saving five. Pushing a person onto the track uses him as a tool to stop the trolley and is forbidden[15]. The humanity formulation captures the moral difference between these cases.

Success: Retributive justice

Kant's retributivism rejects utilitarian punishment. Punishment must be deserved; it must never be inflicted merely to promote social welfare. Kant forbids punishing the innocent to deter crime[14] and insists that punishments be proportional to the wrongdoer's inner wickedness[16]. These principles align with common intuitions about fairness and respect for persons.

Failure: Lying to the murderer

In the "murderer at the door" case, Kant maintained that lying to a murderer about the whereabouts of an intended victim is wrong. Lying manipulates the murderer as a mere means and undermines the institution of truth-telling[29]. Many philosophers and laypeople regard this conclusion as implausible; they believe lying is justified to save innocent lives. Some Kantians propose more nuanced maxims—e.g., lying only when it will likely save lives—that might pass universalization, but this concession relies on assessing consequences and departs from Kant's strict anti-lying stance[30].

Failure: Starving family and theft

Kantian ethics holds that we have a perfect duty not to steal. Therefore, stealing food to feed a starving family is morally impermissible[21]. Many thinkers argue that such rigid adherence to rules ignores morally relevant circumstances and leads to inhumane results.

Failure: Conflicting duties

Suppose you promise to return an item but discover that fulfilling the promise requires lying or stealing. Kant denies that true conflicts of duties occur and insists that any apparent conflict results from a misformulated maxim[22]. Critics argue that this response fails to account for tragic moral dilemmas in which any action violates a duty.

Responses and developments

Modern Kantians have offered various responses to these challenges. Some argue that maxims must be formulated at the appropriate level of generality; adding arbitrary conditions such as “people with nine-letter names” is cheating[31]. Others suggest that the CI, when properly interpreted, includes considerations of ends and circumstances. John Stuart Mill and R.M. Hare have proposed that the universalization test effectively endorses utilitarianism because universal prescriptions require giving equal weight to everyone’s interests[32]. Scholars such as Onora O’Neill and Barbara Herman emphasise the humanity formulation, arguing that it yields substantive positive duties (e.g., beneficence) and can accommodate some role for consequences while maintaining respect for persons.

The SEP notes that Kantian philosophers have explored ways to extend moral status to people with cognitive disabilities by appealing to other aspects of Kant’s philosophy. Some argue that all human beings have dignity regardless of their cognitive capacities, while others claim that respect for all rational agents commits us to valuing non-rational beings as well[33].

Summary table: Kantianism in normative ethics

Aspect	Positive contribution / argument	Criticisms and challenges
Universalization & fairness	The CI’s universal law test prohibits self-serving exceptions and promotes consistency[5].	The test can be gamed by adding arbitrary conditions to maxims[18]; some harmless maxims are non-universalizable[19].
Respect for persons	The humanity formulation demands treating individuals as ends,	Rigid application yields counter-intuitive verdicts; e.g., forbids

Aspect	Positive contribution / argument	Criticisms and challenges
	underpinning prohibitions on lying, exploitation and punishing the innocent[34][13].	lying to save a life[29] and denies moral value to acts motivated by love[24].
Retributive justice	Punishment must be based on desert, not utility; forbids punishing the innocent and requires proportionality[35].	The theory is uncompromising and gives little guidance on determining proportional punishments[36].
Autonomy and rational agency	Moral obligations arise from rational autonomy; persons are self-legislating and possess dignity[8].	Emphasis on rationality risks excluding infants and severely cognitively impaired individuals from moral status[9].
Practical guidance	Distinguishes perfect and imperfect duties, providing a structured account of moral obligations[3].	Critics argue that the CI does not uniquely determine which maxims are morally acceptable and cannot resolve conflicting duties[26][23].
Role of consequences	Kant emphasises that moral worth depends on duty, not outcomes, guarding against sacrificing individuals for the greater good[37].	Many believe that consequences matter; ignoring them leads to implausible results in trolley cases and emergency situations[20].

Conclusion

Kantianism remains one of the most influential theories in normative ethics. Its insistence on universalizable principles, respect for persons and rational autonomy offers a rigorous framework that underpins modern notions of rights and justice. The theory successfully explains why using people merely as tools—such as punishing the innocent or using someone as a human shield—is wrong and why certain intuitive distinctions in trolley dilemmas hold.

However, Kant's framework faces formidable challenges. Critics argue that the Categorical Imperative lacks substantive content, ignores the moral importance of outcomes, yields rigid and sometimes counter-intuitive prescriptions, and relies on a problematic view of free will. The

requirement that only actions done from duty have moral worth seems to undervalue benevolent motives, and the theory's focus on rational agency leaves the moral status of vulnerable individuals uncertain.

Contemporary Kantians have developed nuanced responses, often by refining the formulation of maxims, emphasising the moral relevance of respect, or interpreting the Categorical Imperative in more teleological ways. Whether or not one accepts Kant's moral theory in its original form, it continues to provoke fruitful debate and remains a touchstone for philosophical inquiry into the nature of morality.

[1] [3] [9] [32] [33] [37] Kant's Moral Philosophy (Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy)

<https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/kant-moral/>

[2] [18] [19] [20] [21] [22] [23] [24] [28] [31] Ethical Theories - Philosophy A Level

<https://philosophyalevel.com/aqa-philosophy-revision-notes/ethical-theories/>

[4] [5] [6] [7] [8] [10] [11] [12] [34] Kant, Immanuel | Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy

<https://iep.utm.edu/kantview/>

[13] [14] [16] [17] [35] [36] How can punishment be justified? On Kant's Retributivism – Philosophical Thought

<https://open.library.okstate.edu/introphilosophy/chapter/how-can-punishment-be-justified-on-kants-retributivism/>

[15] [29] [30] Kantian Deontology: Immanuel Kant's Ethics - 1000-Word Philosophy: An Introductory Anthology

<https://1000wordphilosophy.com/2014/06/09/kantian-ethics/>

[25] [26] [27] Critique of Kant's Ethics

<https://spot.colorado.edu/~huemer/papers/kant1.htm>